

QUIETCLUECO PRESENTS

HOST GUIDE



MURDER AT THE LANTERN SUPPER

A MORROWMERE MURDER MYSTERY PARTY

6-12 PLAYERS · 2-3 HOURS · HOST CAN PLAY

HOST GUIDE · NO SPOILERS UNTIL THE SEALED SECTION AT THE END

Welcome to the Lantern Supper

Every Halloween, when the Moon Fair on Morrowmere green has packed away its last lantern, the Hearth Circle climbs the hill to Larkwell Hall for the Lantern Supper: soup and cider by the fire, a midnight carol, and the lighting of the great lantern in the tower.

This year Rowena Heatherly, the Lantern Keeper of the Circle and the owner of the Hall, promised an announcement at midnight. She never made it. At a quarter to eleven her goddaughter found her in the Still Room, a green glass of blackberry cordial empty beside her.

Inspector Hollis Drummond has locked the doors. Nobody leaves Larkwell Hall until the Inspector knows who poisoned Rowena, and the Inspector is counting on you.

At a glance

6–12 players (6 core roles + up to 6 extra) · 2–3 hours · 3 rounds · teens and adults · no acting required · the host can play

The host guide has no spoilers until the sealed section on the last pages. If you want to play, print those pages separately, seal them in an envelope and don't read them until the end.

What's in the kit

- Host guide (this file): how to run the party, casting for 6–12 guests, scripts for every round, the plan of the house and the sealed solution.
- Player kit: 12 character booklets (4 pages each), 11 evidence cards, house rules, the plan of the house, detective's notes, accusation sheets, name badges, a potion menu and 4 awards.
- Invitations: a fillable invitation, 12 character invitations (fillable) and phone versions to text.



How the game works

0

Before the party

Choose the roles for your guest count, send invitations and character invitations, print the kit.

1

Prologue

The host reads the opening. Guests read the first page of their booklet: who they are.

2

Round 1

Evidence cards 1–4. Everyone says who they are and where they were.

3

Round 2

Evidence cards 5–8. Secrets start to come out.

4

Round 3

Evidence cards 9–11. The last pieces fall into place.

5

Accusation and reveal

Everyone writes an accusation. The host opens the sealed solution and reads it aloud. Hand out the awards.

Everyone is a suspect, even the killer doesn't know

No booklet says who did it. Each booklet is a character's memory of the evening: what they will tell, and what they would rather keep quiet until their booklet says to share it. The evidence cards are true. Nobody lies about where someone else was. Put those together and exactly one guest could have poisoned Rowena's glass. That is why the host can play too.

House rules for the table

1. Everyone is a suspect. No booklet says who did it, not even the killer's own. Read your booklet as your character's memory: tell what it tells you, keep your secret until your booklet says to share it.
2. You may not show anyone your booklet. You may read lines aloud.
3. Your character only knows what is in your booklet. If someone asks you something you don't know, say so, or invent something harmless that does not change where anyone was.
4. The evidence cards are true. So is the plan of Larkwell Hall.
5. Nobody lies about where other people were. People can be wrong about themselves.



Before the party

Two to three weeks before

- Decide how many guests you will have (6–12) and choose roles from the casting table.
- Send the invitation, then each guest their character invitation: who they play and what to wear. Everyone can play any role; change first names to suit your guests.

One week before

- Print the player kit: one booklet per guest (only the roles you are using), the evidence cards, the plan of the house, name badges, detective's notes and accusation sheets (one each), the potion menu and the awards.
- Put each booklet in an envelope with the guest's name. Put the evidence cards in three envelopes: Round 1 (cards 1–4), Round 2 (5–8), Round 3 (9–11).
- If you are playing too: print the sealed solution pages separately and seal them without reading.

On the day

- Lanterns, candles (battery ones are safest), a few pumpkins, something purple.
- Make one or two potions from the menu, with and without alcohol.
- Keep a bell, a glass and a spoon, or a pan handy to start each round.

What to print from the player kit

House rules and the plan of the house: 1 copy each, for the table

Character booklets: 1 per guest, 4 pages each

Evidence cards: 1 set (6 pages, cut in half)

Detective's notes and accusation sheet: 1 each per guest

Name badges: the roles you use

Potion menu and awards: 1 each



CHOOSE ROLES FOR YOUR GUEST COUNT

Casting

The six core roles are needed in every game. Each extra guest adds one extra role, in this order. The extra roles bring witnesses, secrets and fun, but the case can always be solved without them.

GUESTS	Cordelia	Marigold	Silas	Clementin	Rufus	Isadora	Mother	Linnet	Tamsin	Percival	Ned	Bryony
6 guests	●	●	●	●	●	●						
7 guests	●	●	●	●	●	●	●					
8 guests	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●				
9 guests	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●			
10 guests	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●		
11 guests	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	
12 guests	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	●

The roles

Cordelia Heatherly · *core* — Rowena's niece, who expects to inherit Larkwell Hall. Charming, impatient and sure the Hall will be hers one day. *Costume: velvet cape.*

Marigold Fenn · *core* — Keeper of the Still Room, the Circle's herbalist. Knows every plant in the garden and holds the only key to the poison cabinet. *Costume: herb apron.*

Silas Ashgrove · *core* — Treasurer of the Hearth Circle. Counts every penny of the lantern fund. Lately, a little too carefully. *Costume: waistcoat & pocket watch.*

Clementine Reed · *core* — Candlemaker, whose workshop is in the Hall's coach house. Makes every candle the Circle burns, and tonight she brought the best of them. *Costume: wax-spattered smock.*

Rufus Hawthorn · *core* — Caretaker and bellringer of Larkwell Hall. Has looked after the Hall for thirty years and rings its bell on every feast night. *Costume: tweed & keys.*

Isadora Quince · *core* — A mapmaker who came to Morrowmere this autumn. A newcomer with sharp eyes, a sharper pencil and a reason for coming she hasn't told anyone. *Costume: travelling cloak.*

Mother Meridew · *extra* — The village tea-leaf reader. Reads cups for anyone who asks, and remembers everything she reads. *Costume: shawls & spoons.*

Linnet Fairweather · *extra* — Rowena's goddaughter, who sings in the choir. Rowena's favourite, and the one who found her. *Costume: star-print dress.*

Tamsin Rook · *extra* — Cook of Larkwell Hall. Runs the kitchen, hears every door in the house and serves the best cider on the hill. *Costume: flour & ladle.*

Percival Hobb · *extra* — Clerk of the Hearth Circle. Writes down everything, especially what people would rather he didn't. *Costume: spectacles & ledger.*

Ned Quarrie · *extra* — Fiddler of the midnight choir. Plays at every wedding, wake and feast in the valley, and never misses a beat. *Costume: fiddle & cap.*

Bryony Fettle · *extra* — The lantern girl. Lights every lantern in Morrowmere and notices every footprint on the way. *Costume: lantern & scarf.*



Hosting tips

If the host plays: take any role, core or extra. You know nothing more than your booklet, so you can play to win. Keep the sealed solution sealed until everyone has made an accusation.

If a guest can't come: drop the last extra role from the list. If a core guest can't come, the host reads that booklet aloud at the start of each round (the host can also play a role).

Bigger group? Pair guests up: two guests share one booklet and play the role as a team.



A SUGGESTED TIMETABLE FOR A 2½-HOUR PARTY

The evening

0:00 Guests arrive. Potions, name badges, booklets in envelopes. Everyone reads page 1 of their booklet.

0:15 Prologue: the host reads the opening (Round scripts).

0:20 Round 1 (about 35 minutes).

0:55 Supper or snack break, optional.

1:15 Round 2 (about 35 minutes).

1:50 Round 3 (about 25 minutes).

2:15 Accusations: everyone fills in a sheet.

2:25 The reveal, then the awards.

Setting the scene

- Lanterns and candles everywhere (battery candles near costumes and paper).
- A green glass on a side table with a card: “Rowena’s cordial — do not drink”.
- Folk fiddle music, low; a bell to start each round.
- Dried herbs, a bowl of apples, a few pumpkins, a purple cloth on the table.
- Food: a pot of soup, crusty bread, cheese, gingerbread, toffee apples.

Potions

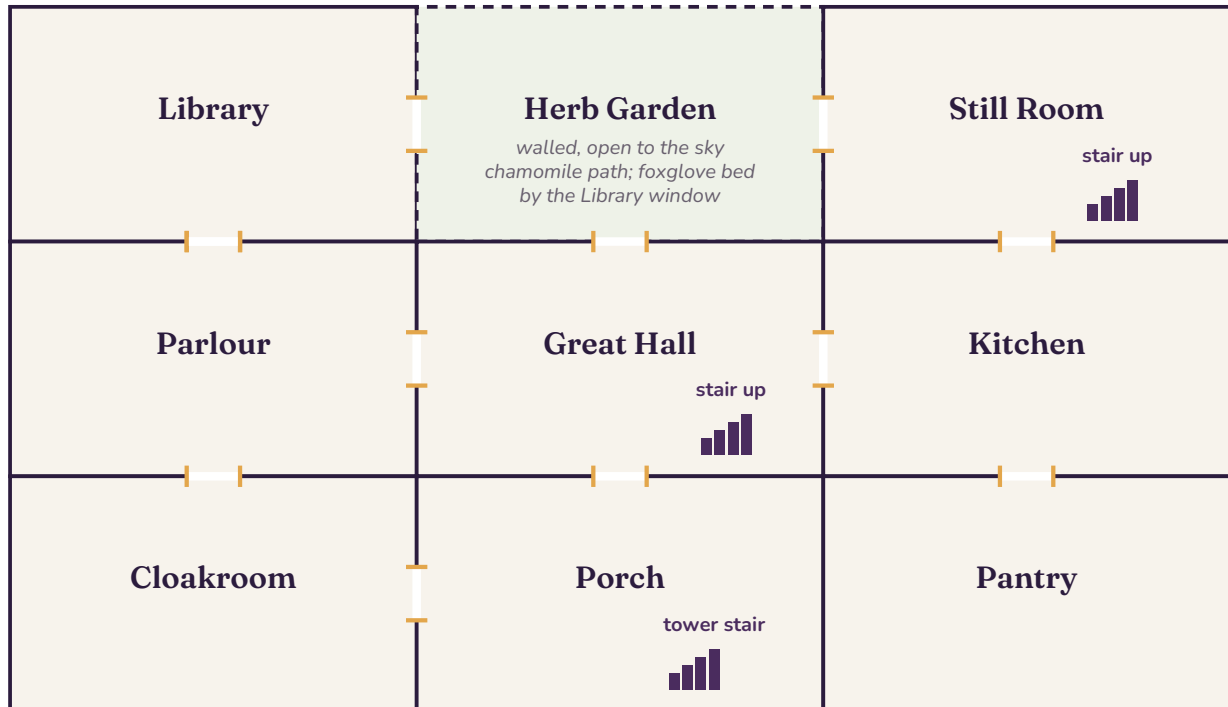
The potion menu in the player kit has four drinks, each with a “spellbound” (with alcohol) and a “moonless” (alcohol-free) version. Decorate with lemon balm, mint or rosemary. Never use foxglove or any garden plant you are not sure of: in this story it is a poison, and in real life it is one too.



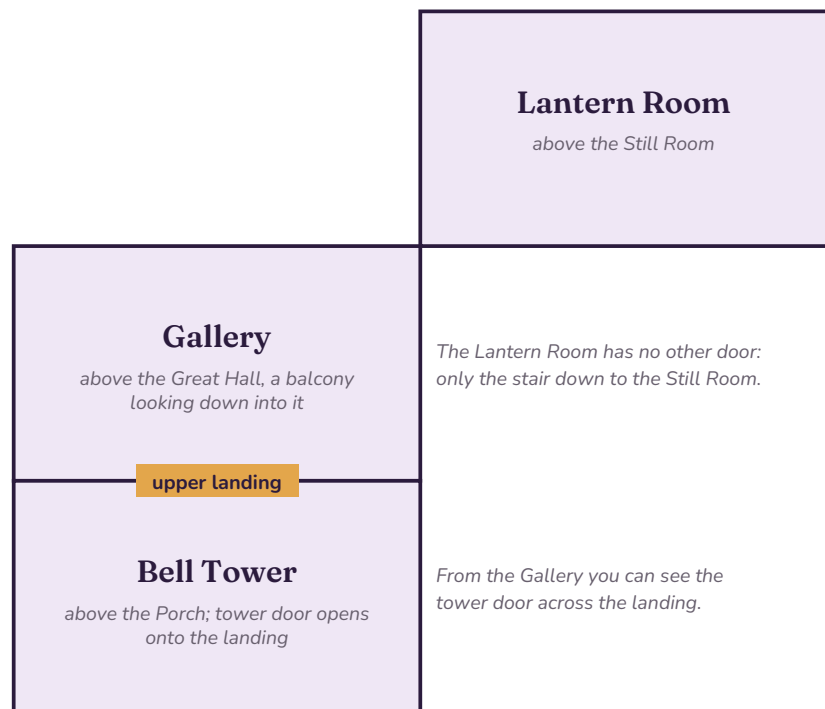
PUT THIS ON THE TABLE WITH THE EVIDENCE CARDS

The plan of Larkwell Hall

GROUND FLOOR (north at the top)



UPPER FLOOR (above the rooms below it)



— door · dashed: outdoors · The Kitchen has a serving hatch into the Great Hall and a window onto the herb garden. The Library's French window and the Great Hall's north door open onto the herb garden; the Still Room has its own garden door.



READ ALOUD WHEN EVERYONE HAS A DRINK

Prologue

“Every Halloween, when the Moon Fair on Morrowmere green has packed away its last lantern, the Hearth Circle climbs the hill to Larkwell Hall for the Lantern Supper: soup and cider by the fire, a midnight carol, and the lighting of the great lantern in the tower.”

“This year Rowena Heatherly, the Lantern Keeper of the Circle and the owner of the Hall, promised an announcement at midnight. She never made it. At a quarter to eleven her goddaughter found her in the Still Room, a green glass of blackberry cordial empty beside her.”

“Inspector Hollis Drummond has locked the doors. Nobody leaves Larkwell Hall until the Inspector knows who poisoned Rowena, and the Inspector is counting on you.”

Then read the house rules aloud, and ask everyone to read the first page of their booklet (“Your character”).

Round 1

Read aloud:

“Ladies and gentlemen, I am sorry to tell you that Rowena Heatherly is dead. Someone put foxglove in her cordial tonight. Every one of you was in this house. Before we go any further, I want to know who you are, and where you were.”

- Put evidence cards 1–4 on the table, face up, and the plan of Larkwell Hall beside them.
- Everyone reads the Round 1 page of their booklet, then introduces themselves to the room. Then mingle: ask questions, compare stories, look at the cards. Around 30–40 minutes.

Round 2

- Ring a bell, clink a glass or bang a pan. Read aloud: “The bell. I keep thinking about the bell. It rang for a quarter of an hour while Rowena was upstairs. Some of you have been less than honest with me. Cards on the table, please, and new ones.”
- Put evidence cards 5–8 on the table.
- Everyone reads the Round 2 page of their booklet. Secrets start to come out. Mingle and question for 30–40 minutes.

Round 3

Read aloud:

“I have one more thing to show you, and two papers from Rowena’s desk. After this, I want your answer.”

- Put evidence cards 9–11 on the table.



- Everyone reads the Round 3 page of their booklet. Last chance to question each other: about 20–30 minutes. Then hand out the accusation sheets.

The accusation

- Give everyone an accusation sheet. Ten minutes, no talking.
- Each guest writes who poisoned Rowena, how they got to the glass, and which evidence proves it.
- Collect the sheets. Then open the sealed solution and read it aloud, slowly. Pause at the name.

The awards

- Best Detective: for seeing through the candle smoke.
- Best Costume: for dressing the part from hat to hem.
- Best Performance: for staying in character all night.
- Most Suspicious: for looking guilty without even trying.
- Best Detective goes to whoever named the killer with the best reasons. Vote on the rest.



Questions hosts ask

Can I play and host? Yes. Nobody's booklet, including yours, says who did it. Just don't read the sealed pages.

Do guests have to act? No. Everything a guest needs to say is in their booklet, in plain words. Hamming it up is welcome, never required.

What if someone reads ahead? Each round is on its own page. Ask guests to fold their booklet so only the current page shows.

What if the guests are stuck? Point them at the plan and at card 1: who could have been in the Still Room while Rowena was upstairs? Then ask who can vouch for whom.

Is it scary? Spooky, not gory: candlelight, a bell, a poisoned cordial. No blood, no weapons. Fine for teens and adults.

Do I need to print in colour? No. The pages are light to save ink; colour looks nicer on the cards and badges.



SEALED SOLUTION

STOP. HOST ONLY. READ AT THE END.

Everything after this page gives away the answer.

If you are playing too, print the remaining pages separately,
fold them, seal them in an envelope and open it after the accusations.



THE SOLUTION • READ ALOUD

The killer is Clementine Reed, the candlemaker.

Why

Rowena meant to take back the coach house where three generations of Reed women had made candles. The notice to quit was written and waiting on her desk with a note: “Sign at midnight.” Clementine begged her at supper; Rowena said she would think about it until midnight. Clementine decided not to wait.

How

Just after a quarter past ten, while the choir sang with their backs to the north door and the peal drowned every footstep, Clementine slipped out of the Great Hall into the herb garden. She tore a few foxglove leaves from the bed by the Library window, crossed the chamomile to the Still Room’s garden door and found the green glass alone on the table: Rowena was upstairs in the Lantern Room. She crushed the leaves into the cordial and went back the way she came. By half past ten she was in her chair by the north door again, a little mud on her hem.

The mistake

As she bent over the glass, a drip of green wax fell from her own lantern onto the rim.

The lie

She said she spent the peal in the Cloakroom looking for her shawl. Her shawl was over the back of her chair by the north door the whole time: Linnet saw an empty chair with a shawl on it.

How the evidence points to her

Card 1, The Green Glass. The poison went in while Rowena was upstairs: after a quarter past ten and before half past. The poisoner was in the Still Room then.

Silas and Isadora (Round 1). They played cards in the Library with Mother Meridew from ten until twenty to eleven, and each says the other never left the table. Nobody in this game lies about where someone else was (house rule 5), so both are cleared.

Card 3, The Choir and the Kitchen. Linnet, Percival, Ned, Bryony, Tamsin and Mother Meridew were all in plain sight. The six extra guests are cleared in Round 1.

Rufus and Cordelia (Round 2). Rufus rang the peal from a quarter past to half past without a break, and saw Cordelia across the landing in the Gallery the whole time; Cordelia saw him at the rope. Each clears the other. That leaves Marigold and Clementine.



Card 9 with Card 2. The wax on the rim is green. The lantern ledger shows three green candles: Cordelia, Silas and Clementine. Marigold's candle was amber. Cordelia and Silas are already cleared, so the poisoner is Clementine Reed.

The red herrings

Marigold's key. The poison cabinet was never opened (card 6). Marigold's trip to the Pantry was about a jar of honey.

Silas and the lantern fund. He took the money, and Rowena knew, but he was at the card table all through the peal.

Cordelia and the will. She tore the will in a temper in the Gallery, in full view of Rufus in the tower.

Isadora. Rowena's daughter and her chosen successor: she had everything to gain from Rowena alive.

The end (read aloud)

Inspector Drummond took Clementine down the hill before midnight. The Hearth Circle lit the great lantern anyway, at one in the morning, and Isadora Quince lit it.

Character, time and place: where everyone really was

WHO	21:30	21:45	22:00	22:15	22:30	22:45
Rowena (victim)	Great Hall	Great Hall	Kitchen	Lantern Room	Still Room	Still Room
Cordelia Heatherly	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Gallery	Gallery	Great Hall
Marigold Fenn	Still Room	Kitchen	Kitchen	Pantry	Kitchen	Kitchen
Silas Ashgrove	Great Hall	Parlour	Library	Library	Library	Great Hall
Clementine Reed	Great Hall	Parlour	Great Hall	Still Room	Great Hall	Great Hall
Rufus Hawthorn	Porch	Porch	Porch	Bell Tower	Bell Tower	Porch
Isadora Quince	Great Hall	Great Hall	Library	Library	Library	Great Hall
Mother Meridew	Great Hall	Great Hall	Library	Library	Library	Great Hall
Linnet Fairweather	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Still Room
Tamsin Rook	Kitchen	Kitchen	Kitchen	Kitchen	Kitchen	Kitchen
Percival Hobb	Porch	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall
Ned Quarrie	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall
Bryony Fettle	Herb Garden	Great Hall	Great Hall	Great Hall	Herb Garden	Great Hall

Each column is the quarter hour starting at that time. Highlighted: the Still Room at a quarter past ten. Clementine said she was in the Cloakroom.

